DSP. While he conceded that ‘it appears many people are purchasing them in Tuticorin’, and assuming that Rs 20,000 would be collected, he said, with sadistic humour, ‘the steamers would be kept very busy for some time carrying free passengers’.[111]

There were other efforts to add ‘mickle to the muckle’. For instance, one dramatic troupe, the Padmanabha Vilasa Drama Company performed a benefit show for SSNCo, and donated Rs 300 from the day’s collection of Rs 450. Similarly, the (Karlekar) Circus company too had a benefit performance in Madras. Referring to these benefit shows, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar asked why other drama troupes and circus companies, not to speak of Bhagavathars and kathakalakshepam (religious discourse set to music and song) performers, should not follow these examples.[112]

A Poet’s Valiant Efforts

None of these efforts can compare with the impractical romanticism of Subramania Bharati (Figure 18). Bharati’s efforts were valiant and noble, if futile. But they bear testimony to the extraordinary idealism the poet exuded and the passion with which he conducted these efforts.